

Earthquake Survival Guide — Before, During, and After

This guide covers exactly what to do when an earthquake strikes. Based on guidelines from FEMA, USGS, American Red Cross, and NDMA. India sits on active seismic zones — the Himalayan belt, Andaman islands, and parts of Gujarat and Maharashtra face significant risk.

NO WARNING EXISTS. Earthquakes strike without any forecast. The actions in this guide must be practised in advance so they become instinct when the shaking starts.

SECTION 1: DURING THE SHAKING — DROP, COVER, HOLD ON

The moment you feel the ground shake, execute three actions immediately regardless of where you are:

DROP to your hands and knees. This prevents the earthquake from knocking you off your feet and controls how far you fall.

COVER your head and neck with one arm and hand. If a sturdy table or desk is within reach, crawl under it. If no shelter is nearby, press against an interior wall away from windows and cover your head with both arms.

HOLD ON if under shelter — grip it with one hand and move with it. Be ready to move with the furniture if it shifts.

Stay in this position until the shaking completely stops. Do not try to run during shaking — most injuries occur when people try to move and are struck by falling objects.

If you are in bed:

Stay in bed. Turn face-down and cover your head and neck with your pillow. The risk of falling objects is lower if you stay flat. Only get up when shaking stops.

If you are outdoors:

Move to an open area away from buildings, trees, streetlights, and power lines. Drop to the ground and cover your head with your arms. Stay away from building walls — falling bricks and glass are the leading cause of outdoor earthquake deaths.

If you are in a vehicle:

Pull over and stop away from buildings, trees, overpasses, and utility wires. Set the parking brake. Stay inside with your seatbelt on until shaking stops. Proceed cautiously after — check for road damage before driving.

MYTHS to ignore:

Do NOT stand in a doorway. This is an outdated myth. Doorways offer no more protection than any other part of a modern building and you risk being hit by the swinging door.

Do NOT run outside during shaking. You are more likely to be struck by falling debris outside a building entrance than staying put under cover.

SECTION 2: IMMEDIATELY AFTER SHAKING STOPS

Step 1. Check yourself for injuries before helping others. You cannot help others effectively if you are injured.

Step 2. Check others nearby. Provide first aid for bleeding (direct pressure) or unconsciousness (CPR if not breathing). Do NOT move anyone with a possible spinal injury unless they face immediate danger.

Step 3. Put on sturdy shoes immediately. Broken glass and debris on the floor cause many post-earthquake injuries.

Step 4. Check for gas leaks. If you smell gas or hear hissing: open windows, leave the building immediately, do not use any electrical switches or open flames, do not use your phone inside. Call the gas company from outside.

Step 5. Check for fire. Earthquakes rupture gas lines and break electrical wires. If there is a small fire and you know how to use a fire extinguisher, act immediately. If the fire is large, leave the building and move far away.

Step 6. If you are in a damaged building, exit carefully and move away from the building. Do not re-enter until it has been inspected and declared safe.

Step 7. If you are near the coast, move immediately to higher ground inland. A major earthquake can generate a tsunami that arrives within minutes. Do not wait for an official warning.

AFTER THE TSUNAMI WARNING: If an earthquake lasted 20 seconds or more and you are near the coast, treat it as a tsunami warning regardless of whether an official alert has been issued. Move inland immediately.

SECTION 3: AFTERSHOCKS — EXPECT THEM

Aftershocks follow every major earthquake. They can occur minutes, hours, days, or even weeks after the main event. Some aftershocks are nearly as strong as the original earthquake.

Every time you feel shaking, immediately Drop, Cover, and Hold On again.

Do not be inside damaged buildings during aftershocks — they can cause already-weakened structures to collapse.

SECTION 4: IF YOU ARE TRAPPED UNDER DEBRIS

Stay calm. People have survived for days trapped under rubble.

Do not light matches or lighters. Earthquake dust can be flammable. There may also be gas leaks. Sparks or flames can cause a fire or explosion.

Do not shout continuously. Shouting wastes energy and can cause you to inhale dangerous dust. Instead:

Signal by tapping. Knock on a pipe, wall, or any solid surface three times repeatedly. Rescuers are trained to listen for tapping sounds.

Use a whistle if you have one. Three blasts is the universal distress signal.

Send a text message if you have phone signal. SMS can get through even when voice calls cannot. Send your location.

Cover your mouth with a piece of clothing to avoid inhaling concrete dust. Dust inhalation causes serious lung damage.

Stay still. Moving around risks destabilizing the debris above you and causing secondary collapse.

CRUSH SYNDROME WARNING: If someone has been trapped under heavy weight for more than 15 minutes, do NOT attempt to remove the debris yourself unless you are confident it is safe. When a crushed limb is suddenly released, toxins that built up in the compressed muscles flood the bloodstream and can cause cardiac arrest and kidney failure. Rapid removal of heavy debris requires medical supervision. Keep the person calm and call for professional rescue.

SECTION 5: COMMON EARTHQUAKE INJURIES AND FIRST AID

The most common earthquake injuries are cuts from broken glass, fractures from falling debris, head injuries, and crush injuries.

Cuts and bleeding: Apply direct firm pressure with the cleanest available cloth. Do not remove it once applied — add more cloth on top if it soaks through. See the wound and bleeding guide for detailed steps.

Fractures: Do not attempt to straighten a broken bone. Immobilise it in the position you find it using sticks, boards, or rolled newspapers as splints. Tie above and below the injury — not over it.

Head injuries: Keep the person still. If unconscious but breathing, place in recovery position. If not breathing, begin CPR. Do not give water or food.

Dust inhalation: Move to fresh air immediately. Cover the mouth and nose with a damp cloth to filter dust while moving through debris.